The Family Conversation About Dad

Getting to one account of what's happening, with the differences written down instead of argued out.

Your sister was there when it happened. Your brother talked to the doctor. You've been at the house every day. Each of you is holding a different piece, and Dad has his own account of the week.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: put the pieces side by side and write down an account everyone recognizes. It isn't for deciding what happens next.

Who should be there

Dad, if he's willing. It's his week you're putting together, and the Family Caregiver Alliance points out that the person being cared for usually doesn't want to be left out, and that their preferences for care have to be considered. Then everyone who has a part in his care or a piece of the story: the one who was there when it happened, the one who spoke with the doctor, the one who is at the house most. A neighbor, a family friend or a paid caregiver can be part of it, and someone who can't travel can join by phone. [1]

Ask one person to take the notes and a different person to keep the conversation moving.

How to open

Start with Dad, and start by listening. The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice for family meetings is to hold off on solving anything until the issues have been heard, and to list them as they are shared. [1]

- “Dad, a lot has happened this week and each of us has heard a different part of it. We'd like to put it together, and we'd like to start with how it's been for you.”
- “Nobody here has the whole story. Let's get every piece written down before we talk about what to do.”
- Say what the conversation is for: one account. Say what it isn't for: choosing what happens next, or settling who is right.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

1. What happened, as you remember it?

2. What has changed for you since then?

3. What have we got wrong, or left out?

Ask each other

1. What did you see or hear yourself, and what were you told by someone else?

2. What has changed, and when did you first notice it?

3. Who do you think is coordinating Dad's care right now?

4. What decision do you think our family has to make next, and has anyone given you a date?

5. What don't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

Keep Dad's account in his own words. Where two people remember something differently, write both and leave them side by side. Where nobody knows, write “not yet known” instead of the likeliest guess.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	SAW IT, OR WAS TOLD	REMEMBERED DIFFERENTLY BY
“I slipped on the back step Thursday morning. I was fine by lunchtime.”	Dad	Was there	My sister, who was with him, remembers it as Wednesday
The doctor's office wants to hear from the family by Friday.	My brother	Told by the office, by phone, on Tuesday	My sister heard “sometime next week”

What not to decide yet

These take more than one conversation, and some of them take a professional who has met Dad. Your account is what they will start from. Leave them open.

- Where Dad should live, or what should change.
- Whether he is safe where he is.

- Which of the options people have suggested is the right one.
- Whose version is correct.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the account and send it to everyone, Dad included.
- Who will take each open question to the person who can answer it.
- Who will bring the account to the next care conversation, and when that is.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a disagreement, choose among the options, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one written account, with the differences and the unknowns left on it.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one account now, with Dad's words in it and the differences left standing. The care interview takes that account further, through his living arrangement, his typical day and each area of daily life, and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting